CHAPTER 34

BOXING DAY

26 December 2010

AUSTRALIA vs ENGLAND, 4th Test, *MCG*, *Melbourne*

Australia 98 and 258; England 513

England won by an innings and 157 runs

Australia 1st innings: **J Anderson 16–4–44–4; C Tremlett 11.5–5– 26–4**

The Boxing Day Test is the centre of the Australian sporting calendar. For decades, they have made it a kind of blood sport. Always sold out, every single one of the 85,000 seats occupied, every four years, and it feels like the whole of Melbourne come out for Pom bashing. It's almost as if it's a public holiday in itself, a divine right by now, an event of entitlement that we are pre-destined to walk away from, humbled.

I am back where it began – the MCG – where I have only known defeat. We are tied 1-1 in the series, an overseas Ashes that has been closer than any in my lifetime. It's one we have an actual chance of winning. There is a different feeling entirely to this series. We have laid punches on Australia that have scarred them, leaving them like a heavyweight reaching to clinch, head bowed as they buy time, happy to just receive punches to the body. The first Test concluded with us, batting to initially 'save the game', at 517-1 with Cook and Trott undefeated. I do not watch much of this rearguard, choosing instead to sleep and recover in ice baths, but I can tell from the body language as they walk off that Cooky and Trotty have made brutal psychological incisions.

Mitchell Johnson, in the last Test at the WACA, has shouted from the non-striker's end at me at my mark: 'Why're you chirping now, mate? Not